

THREE R's OF RENEWAL

TEXT: 2 Samuel 5:17-25 (NKJV) *“Now when the Philistines heard that they had anointed David king over Israel, all the Philistines went up to search for David. And David heard of it and went down to the stronghold.¹⁸ The Philistines also went and deployed themselves in the Valley of Rephaim (The valley of the giants).¹⁹ So David inquired of the LORD, saying, “Shall I go up against the Philistines? Will You deliver them into my hand?” And the LORD said to David, “Go up, for I will doubtless deliver the Philistines into your hand.”²⁰ So David went to Baal Perazim (The Lord of the breakthrough), and David defeated them there; and he said, “The LORD has broken through my enemies before me, like a breakthrough of water.” Therefore he called the name of that place Baal Perazim.²¹ And they left their images there, and David and his men carried them away (Oh the taste of victory – They were so fearful, they left their gods). ²² Then the Philistines went up once again and deployed themselves in the Valley of Rephaim (The valley of the giants).²³ Therefore David inquired of the LORD, and He said, “You shall not go up; circle around behind them, and come upon them in front of the mulberry trees.²⁴ “And it shall be, when you hear the sound of marching in the tops of the mulberry trees (The sound of horses running through the tops of the trees), then you shall advance quickly. For then the LORD will go out before you to strike the camp of the Philistines.”²⁵ And David did so, as the LORD*

commanded him; and he drove back the Philistines from Geba (Gee-baw) as far as Gezer (Gay-zer).”

INTRO: Set the scene... Vs. 17-21

The taste of victory is tremendous, but victory is only temporary. As soon as today's victory is won we must be in the process of preparation for tomorrow's battle.

Almost everything has need of periodic renewal. People - houses - vehicles - organizations - ministries - churches - etc. Organizations fail for lack of renewal. Swiss watchmakers refused to adjust to the advent of the invention of the quartz watch and they lost their domination of the world watch-making market.

Our fellowship is in need of renewal from top to bottom:

- Average A.M. attendance – 143
- Median age of A/G minister – 51
- In 1995 we opened 274 churches and 215 churches were closed. Net gain of 59 churches...
- In 2005 258 churches were opened and 237 churches were closed. Net gain 21 churches...
- Between the years of 1995 and 2005 the U.S. A/G church grew from 2,387,982 to 2,830,861 adherents. A net gain of 442,969. This sounds pretty good on the surface but in ten years we only had an 18.55% growth rate extrapolated out over a ten year period! This is 1.85% per year...

- During the same period the worldwide fellowship more than doubled, growing from 25,219,790 to 54,717,677.

The worst thing that can happen to any organization is a lack of introspection and a failure to adjust to the times. Our message must never change but our methods must be in a constant state of metamorphosis.

When renewal does not occur the following things happen:

- Decay
- Disrepair
- Decline
- Lack of motivation
- Loss of interest
- Reversal

The shelf life of Christian leaders is growing shorter every day due to burnout, disillusionment, and lack of tangible success. 86 ministers leave the ministry every day! How do we prevent this? By knowing we are called and embarking on a voyage of development that does not cease until they throw dirt in our face.

In short; if renewal does not occur pretty often, the leader will burnout and the organization will crash and burn! No-one wants to leave a legacy or epitaph of failure. Everyone wants to succeed. The difference between success and failure is times of renewal and adjustment. (Larissa told her grandparents that she was going to make the WNBA and whether or not they

came to her games would determine if they were to go to a good nursing home or a bad one!)

If we are to make our church and individual ministries relevant and effective into the future we can ill afford to rest on the pinnacle of yesterday's victory. (David - When he attacked the enemy and won - A few days' later they were back again - He enquired of the Lord and the Lord told him not to do things the same way!) I know he was not Assembly of God! Things went so well before, there would be no need to pray!

The seven last words of a dying church are, "*We've never done it that way before...*"

Our spiritual walk, our church and individual ministries are in constant need of renewal! [The following are three R's of renewal.](#)

I. REINVENT...

2 Samuel 5:22-23 (NKJV) "***Then the Philistines went up once again and deployed themselves in the Valley of Rephaim (The valley of the giants).²³ Therefore David inquired of the LORD, and He said, "You shall not go up..."***

One of the most important lessons the church needs to learn is, just because it worked a decade or two ago is no reason to believe it will work today! Our message must remain consistent but our methods must constantly be undergoing evaluation and change.

Reinvent Programs – Determine what is working for you and be in a constant state of fine tuning. In the process of fine tuning, if you make a decision that is destructive rather than constructive, STOP IT! (Two service Sunday morning schedule with SS in between)

Reinvent People - Continually evaluate the strengths of those in your down-line – Adjust their responsibilities to compliment their strengths.
(PLACE)

Reinvent Ourselves - Continually evaluate what you are doing and how you are doing it. (Listened to my own tapes – I told Susan, “*I sounded angry.*” She said, “*You were!*”)

Even though David and his men had experienced enormous success in the battle of yesterday they had to reinvent a battle plan for tomorrow’s victory! Each task calls for different gifts. Don't be afraid to change you!

II. REAFFIRM...

2 Samuel 5:22-24 (NKJV) “ ***Then the Philistines went up once again and deployed themselves in the Valley of Rephaim*** (The valley of the giants).²³ ***Therefore David inquired of the LORD, and He said, “You shall not go up; circle around behind them, and come upon them in front of the mulberry trees.***²⁴ ***“And it shall be, when you hear the sound of marching in the tops of the mulberry trees*** (The sound of horses running through the tops of the trees), ***then you shall advance quickly...***” I am pretty sure David was not

Assembly of God because any Assembly of God leader knows if it worked once it will work eternally!

We must remember, God is a God of variety and he rarely does anything the same way twice. David recognized this and if he had failed to consult with God concerning today's battle he would have lost all the momentum he had gained in yesterday's victory. Rather than running the risk of losing ground he had gained he asked God about His strategy for today's victory! He has a strategy for victory for each of our battles!

Reaffirm Programs - Constantly evaluate programs for effectiveness. If a ministry has grown obsolete or ineffective do one of three things:

- Adjust it! Don't be afraid to tweak what you are doing! The larger you grow the more important this becomes!
- Repackage it! Call it something besides Sunday school if necessary... (Christian Education, Discipleship Training, etc... Believe it or not, it does not have to happen on Sunday morning at 9:45!)
- Kill it! Riding a dead horse carries with it three devastating results; The seat is too low to the ground to be comfortable; the scenery looks much the same at all times; the smell will eventually get to you! Don't be afraid to bury a dead horse! The only people who will be offended are those who have never known any thing other than the smell of death!

[Reaffirm People](#) – We must be constantly reaffirming and encouraging people! I must force myself to do this. I am a very driven person, no-one has to pat me on the back to encourage me to do my job, and do it well – this is what I do and I pour everything into it! I expect everyone else to do the same! (When I held my first staff meeting at CT I told the staff, *“It does not matter how much I like you or how close I get to you, there is one word you must remember; PRODUCE – when you fail to PRODUCE, you will be working elsewhere.”*) Because I am a work-a-holic and a perfectionist I must constantly remind myself to reaffirm people. [People need to be reaffirmed in the following ways:](#)

- [Cards...](#)
- [Calls...](#)
- [A pat on the back...](#)
- [Public recognition...](#)

Do you think David needed to reaffirm the soldiers when he told them they were going to ***“Sneak around behind the enemy and wait until they heard horses running through the tops of the mulberry trees”***?

[Reaffirm Ourselves](#) – Sometimes we must encourage ourselves in the Lord! This can be accomplished with a dedicated time of prayer and the Word each day. Other [things we must do to reaffirm ourselves:](#)

- [Ongoing evaluation...](#)
- [Ongoing education ...](#)
- [Work on our strengths...](#)
- [Overcome our weaknesses...](#)

Do you think David needed any affirmation when God spoke to him about horses running through the tops of trees? He probably said something like, *“If you want them to know, tell them yourself!”* (Shane Gore)

III. RELEASE...

2 Samuel 5:22-25 (NKJV) *“Then the Philistines went up once again and deployed themselves in the Valley of Rephaim (The valley of the giants).²³ Therefore David inquired of the LORD, and He said, “You shall not go up; circle around behind them, and come upon them in front of the mulberry trees.²⁴ “And it shall be, when you hear the sound of marching in the tops of the mulberry trees (The sound of horses running through the tops of the trees), then you shall advance quickly. For then the LORD will go out before you to strike the camp of the Philistines.”²⁵ And David did so, as the LORD commanded him; and he drove back the Philistines from Geba (Gee-baw) as far as Gezer (Gay-zer).”*

The moment arrived when David had to release his men to go out and do the will of God! He could not do it all himself, he had to trust them to do what he had trained and instructed them to do! Would they do it exactly as he would do it? Probably not, but they would certainly do it within the framework of the instructions he had given them!

This is something that does not come naturally to me because I am a perfectionist, I want things done right! Everything!!! My theme for years was, *“It’s not what you expect but what you inspect”!!!* **When we release a**

thing, we must allow for the task to be accomplished with the personality of the leader being dominant. No two personalities are alike. The final product is the ultimate thing not the process!

We must:

- Release Programs... Working programs & failing programs!
- Release People... Assign responsibility - Grant authority – Support publicly, correct privately - Give credit!
- Release Ourselves – Release yourself to do what you are called to – Release yourself to do what you are good at – Release yourself from responsibilities that consume large amounts of time and have little or no return!

David could lead his men into battle but he could not fight the battle alone! We are not superman; we cannot succeed solely on our own ability! Together, these men were successful! Any one of them standing alone would have failed. Three things that made them successful were;

- God...
- The Leader...
- Obedient Followers...

When David heard from God and released his men to do the will of God the victory was secured. 2 Samuel 5:24-25 (NKJV) ***“And it shall be, when you hear the sound of marching in the tops of the mulberry trees (The sound of horses running through the tops of the trees), then you shall advance quickly. For then the***

LORD will go out before you to strike the camp of the Philistines. *”25 And David did so, as the LORD commanded him; and he drove back the Philistines from Geba* (Gee-baw) *as far as Gezer* (Gay-zer).”

David was successful in leading his men from the valley of giants to a breakthrough because he; reinvented; reaffirmed and released his men to do the will of God!